

FRONTIER

A card-laying and combination game of nerve, alliances, and the last dollar

Decks	1× American Playing Cards (50 cards)
Excluded Cards	None
Players	2–6
Duration	approx. 20–30 minutes
Complexity	Medium to High

1. Objective

5 rounds. Everyone starts with **\$10** (Standard variant). Each round, every player plays a card combination and bets money on it; the strongest combination wins the pot. **After round 5, whoever has the most money wins.**

2. The Deck

Color	Symbol	Count
Blue	Spades	10
Blue	Clubs	10
Red	Hearts	10
Red	Diamonds	10
Black	Stars	10

Each symbol has 10 cards: 1 through 9 plus the **Cypher (Ø)**, which counts as 10. Black is **neutral** — it can join either Red or Blue, but only as a weaker addition, not a full member (see Section 5).

The Circle: The Cypher links 9 and 1 cyclically — runs may wrap across it (e.g. 8–9–Ø–1 or Ø–1–2). The 1 still counts as a 1 in value — the wraparound is a structural advantage, not a value bonus (see Example A).

3. Setup

Shuffle the deck. Each player receives \$10 and draws 1 card — hand size increases by 1 each round (round 5 = 5 cards).

The first starting player is determined randomly (e.g. by draw, or highest card drawn).

After that, the starting player rotates one seat each round (bankrupt players are skipped).

4. Round Structure

The Market Card: Before the first bet, the top card of the draw pile is revealed. Any player may voluntarily count it as one of their own hand cards in their combination.

Each player takes one turn: choose cards (face down, 1 up to all), then bet.

- **Open:** The first player bets at least \$1 or folds.
- **Call/Raise:** Each following player matches the bet or raises (at least \$1 more than the current bet). The last player in the round may only call or fold, not raise.
- **Limit:** No bet may exceed what the poorest active opponent still has — so they can always call by going all-in.
- **Fold:** No cards, no bet, no claim on the pot.

Showdown: The strongest combination wins the pot (Sections 5 and 7). Ties are split, with any odd dollar going to the first winner in turn order.

After: Played cards are discarded, the deck is reshuffled, and everyone draws up to the new hand size — even players who folded. Anyone with \$0 is eliminated.

Refill (once per game): Before your own bet, you may discard any number of hand cards and draw the same number of new ones.

5. The Hierarchy

Base Rule: More cards always beat fewer cards — regardless of rank. Only when card counts are equal does the table decide. Both a Run and Same Value can be formed with as few as 2 cards (a Run, e.g. 4–5; Same Value, e.g. a pair).

Tier	Category	Condition
1	Run + Symbol	Sequence, one symbol
2	Same Value	Any symbols
3	Run + Pure Color	Sequence, one side, no black
4	Run + Color Alliance	Sequence, one side + black mixed
5	Mixed Run	Sequence, red and blue mixed

6	Symbol, no run	One symbol, no sequence
7	Pure Color, no run	One side without black, no sequence
8	Color Alliance, no run	One side + black, no sequence
9	Chaos	None of the above applies

Twin Special Case: A twin (2 cards of equal value) can never be "Symbol" (each symbol has every value only once). It counts as "Same Value" (category 2) instead — regardless of whether the two cards share a side.

Ties: Within the same category, the total sum of card values decides (Cypher = 10). This also resolves the Circle case correctly: a run that wraps through the 1 remains weaker in value than a straight run (Example A).

6. Victory

After round 5, the player with the most money wins (ties are split). With your new bankroll, you can go straight into further games.

7. Examples

A — The Circle Is No Free Ride

9-Ø-1 (using the circle) sums to $9+10+1 = 20$. 8-9-Ø (straight) sums to $8+9+10 = 27$. Both are runs of equal length and purity — the straight run wins despite having the same top card (Ø).

B — Formation Beats Mass

A pair (Same Value) beats four chaotic cards (Chaos) — formation always beats non-formation, regardless of card count.

C — Pure Before Color Alliance

Two 3-card runs in red: Hearts+Diamonds+Hearts (no black) is "Pure Color" (rank 3). Hearts+Stars+Diamonds (with a Stars card) is only "Color Alliance" (rank 4). The pure run wins despite identical values.

D — The Cypher's Quiet Rise

Ø-1-2 of the same symbol is at the same time a Run + Symbol (rank 1) — the strongest category of all, even though the lowest card in the deck (the 1) is part of it.

E — Two Beats a Twin

Two consecutive cards of the same symbol (e.g. Spades-4 + Spades-5) count as "Run + Symbol" (rank 1) and beat a twin (e.g. two fives of different symbols, "Same Value", rank 2) — at equal card count, category decides first.

8. FAQ

Why keep betting if I can no longer win round 5?

Frontier is designed as a casino game: there isn't just one winner. Any player who leaves with more money than they brought has won — regardless of who's ahead after round 5. The money you leave the table with is your winnings and can be used for further games. The \$10 starting stake applies to the Standard variant; other tables may play with different stakes.

9. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Tier	Rank of a category in the hierarchy (1 = strongest)
Cypher	Value 10; closes the circle between 9 and 1
Symbol	Same symbol (e.g. only Spades)
Coalition / Color	Same side (Union or Confederacy)
Pure Color	One side, without black
Color Alliance	One side, mixed with black
Series / Run	Sequence of consecutive values (2 or more cards)
Kind	Multiple cards (2 or more) of equal value
Chaos	No category applies
Market Card	Revealed draw card, usable by everyone
Refill	One-time partial hand exchange per game
Bet / Call / Raise / Fold	The betting actions
Pot	All bets in a round

The Freedom of Cards

American Playing Cards was introduced by Simon Allmer on the USA's 250th Independence Day. Frontier is only one of many games with this card system.

Learn more at simonallmer.com/americanplayingcards!

